

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

The Greatest Conlang Ever

And five steps to make it yourself



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auyi! I want to start by dispelling the following two myths:

- Conlanging is easy.
- Conlanging is hard.

Most beginner conlangers fall into one of two categories: the scared puppy and the bouncy puppy. Scared puppies will see terms like "concatenative" and "valency operations" and be so intimidated by it that they quit soon after they begin. This scares them from learning and exploring, perhaps because they're perfectionist, apathetic, or annoyed.

Bouncy puppies, on the other hand, assume that their conlang can't be that bad. After all, it fixes all the stupid things that their native language does and adds some super cool features from, like, Nahuatl or something. They will excitedly jump around, shove their work in people's faces, and make a general mess. This is likely due to excitement, overconfidence, and unrealistic expectations.

The fact is, conlanging is not as easy as the bouncy puppy thinks, but it's not as esoteric as the scared puppy thinks either. You just need to find the right foundation and start off on the right foot.

What makes a conlang good?

Regardless of whether you want an alien language or an Indo-European language, all conlangers want to create something good. "Goodness" is so vital to the human condition, that the concept is one of the few "lexical universals" (i.e., essentially every language has a word for "good" or "goodness"). According to Deborah Hill (1987), who wrote her dissertation on value-judgement terms like "good" and "bad," something is good when it is as it should be. Therefore, if you want a good conlang, you need to decide what it should be.

In other words, what are your **goals** for your conlang? What should the conlang be? The thing about puppies, whether scared or bouncy, is that they don't have many goals in life. They're erratic, difficult to contain, and sometimes unbearably annoying. However, with a little training, they will figure out what makes a dog a good dog; things like loyalty, companionship, and standing still when you're trying to take a photo of them.

Here are five steps that will help you generate a good conlang:

1. Define your goals.
2. Study your goals.
3. Implement your goals.
4. Evaluate your goals.
5. Celebrate your goals.

Define your goals

You may already have a few, but here are some key areas where your goals will be important as you develop your conlang.

- **Naturalism.** Regardless of whether you want your conlang to seem natural or unnatural, you need to research what real languages do and don't so that you can follow or deviate as needed.
- **The Speakers.** Language is inseparable from culture; therefore, you want a language that represents its speakers well.
- **The Medium.** For example, if you want to use the conlang in a D&D Campaign, you want it to be challenging and interesting enough for the players who are interacting with it. Other mediums include novels, films, community building, and personal enjoyment.
- **Aesthetics.** The "feel" of a language is important to help you stay engaged with the language. If you or others don't like how it looks and sounds, then it'll get boring or frustrating very quickly. We like pretty things.

Many conlangers make adding certain features or ideas a goal in itself and decide to conlang using "creative restraints." These also count as goals.

Study your goals

If you want a language that "feels" Celtic, then pick up some Irish, Welsh, and Scottish grammars and read all about what makes Celtic feel Celtic. If you want a language for a novel, pick up a novel that uses a conlang and see what the authors before you have done. If you want a language with a specific typology - say agglutinative - then find some agglutinative languages like Hungarian or Lakota and read about how they agglutinate. This is helpful regardless of whether naturalism is a goal.

I discourage you from copying features from other natural languages wholesale, but it's good to have a general idea of how other languages do things and then tweak it for your own conlang.

Implement your goals

Oftentimes, we run straight to implementation and quickly find ourselves in a huge mess. Thankfully, once we've reached this step, we've already defined and studied our goals. Implementation usually follows this path:

Brainstorm → Experiment → Apply → Tweak → Set

Yes, that is an acronym. BEATS.

Brainstorming is literally listing off ideas that you like regardless of whether they're good ideas or not. **Experimenting** is when you hypothetically add a feature from your brainstorming and see whether it plays well with the rest of the conlang. **Applying** is when the feature tests out and you decide that you want to pursue it as a permanent piece of your conlang. **Tweaking** is making inevitable changes to the feature as you continue to expand and learn more about your conlang. **Setting** is the final step when the tweaking is over, and you set the feature in place as a definitive and fully developed part of your conlang. This last step is kind of wishful thinking, as you will likely be tweaking your conlang for its entire active existence.

Evaluate your goals

Once your conlang is "complete," or at least at a functional stage, look back and ask yourself if what you've made has accomplished your goals. If not, you have two choices: 1) change your conlang or 2) change your goals.

Celebrate your goals

And if you have puppies at the party, invite me.

Conclusion

Thoughts

It is guaranteed that at some point in your conlanging, you will become stuck. In these times, it is always best to go back to your goals, then to studying, then to implementing with the BEATS process, then to evaluating. Let's say you're stuck on verbs. You can look back at what your goals are and see if you can accomplish any of them with your verbs. Study verb systems that would accomplish those goals and gather as much information as you can. Then, try the BEATS process. After you've got something, evaluate what you've done and determine if it's "good" (i.e., as it should be, according to your original goals).

Questions

1. Do you identify the most with the scared puppy or the bouncy puppy? How do you know? And what kind of attitude do you need to transform into a good loyal companion?
2. What are the goals for your conlang? Identify at least one from each category: naturalism, speakers, medium, and aesthetics.
3. Out of the 'Brainstorm > Experiment > Apply > Tweak > Set' process, which step(s) do you often skip over?
4. When's the celebration party and who's invited?